FARIA · 7 NOVEMBER 2026 · A LESSON FOR JEFF FRANZEN

Jeremiah Dixon: the surveyor in the partnership

Jeremiah Dixon was born in 1733 at Cockfield, in County Durham, into a Quaker family with means. He trained as a surveyor and worked as an amateur astronomer. When the Royal Society needed a second man for the 1761 transit, John Bird's recommendation is the account to trust, and to trust only as far as it goes. Bird made instruments and knew both worlds, the workshop and the observatory. A family story about an examination at Woolwich is thinner: the Ordnance minutes that would confirm it have not been produced. Say "recommended through Bird's network," not "we watched them meet."

A Quaker surveyor in the north of England already knew how a chain lies, how a slope cheats a distance, and how a neighbor disputes a hedge. That craft is not astronomy, and astronomy is not that craft. The Royal Society needed both on one road, which is why the pairing matters more than which man stood an inch to the left.

Dixon was not a spare hand hired to hold Mason's chain. At the Cape he observed. On the boundary, from 1763, surveying was his profession and astronomy was Mason's daily habit. The work needed both. A chain of standard length, a slope corrected, a trial line checked by a second measurement: those are the surveyor's corrections, and they are legitimate. They are not a confession that the first number was a scandal.

In October 1767 the Six Nations escort stopped at the war path. Their leader told the party that this was as far as his commission from the chiefs ran, and that he would not go one step farther west. That sentence is about a limit set by the people who sent him. It is not a license to invent a speech about fear, and it is not a permission slip written by the geometry. Some of the hired men, separately, had already refused to cross a river for fear of the Shawnee and the Delaware. Two facts. Do not melt them into one slogan.

Dixon died in Britain in 1779. The line he helped lay is the next lesson. Mason's lesson has the Greenwich years and the rule that a place must be known before a sight is interpreted. The pair only works if you can see both men.

The illustrated lesson is download the PDF.

Sources

- Edwin Danson, FIG 2002: https://www.fig.net/resources/proceedings/fig_proceedings/fig_2002/HS1/HS1_danson.pdf

- Todd Babcock, FIG 2002: https://www.fig.net/resources/proceedings/fig_proceedings/fig_2002/HS1/HS1_babcock.pdf
- The 1767 letter, Swarthmore transcription: https://peterschmidt.domains.swarthmore.edu/engl52b/m-d.letter.html

Key facts

- Dixon was born in 1733 at Cockfield, County Durham, and worked as a surveyor and amateur astronomer.
- Bird's recommendation brought him to Mason. The literal first meeting is unknown, and the Woolwich exam story is unverified.
- He observed at the Cape in 1761 and surveyed the boundary from 1763. Planned corrections are part of the method.
- In October 1767 the escort stopped at the commission's geographic limit. Dixon died in Britain in 1779.